

SKOAR! Special

A level playing field

Bontago is a puzzle and real time strategy game which involves the placing of blocks on a circular playing area known as a "field". Gameplay involves smartly arranging blocks on the field. These blocks show up as the cursor, tetris style, and you have to scatter the blocks around the field to increase the area of your coverage. This area is a coloured overlay on the field, that shows how much of the field you have covered. The area extends a little beyond the blocks, and is calculated using three factors. The size of the blocks in the first factor, the proximity to other blocks is the second, and the height of stacks of blocks is the third. A player has to use a combination of scattering the blocks and building towers to win. The objective of the game



The red camp extending it's defences and almost capturing the flag

is to capture a flag by extending the area of the influence of your blocks before the enemy does.

The game is initially a little difficult to figure out, but once you get the hang of it, it can be pretty addictive and demanding. Each game is a fresh map, and there is no campaign. There is a very short and easy to master tutorial that explains the concepts of the game. Up to eight players can play at once in a multiplayer map, and when the gifts start coming down, the gameplay quickly snowballs into something pretty intense.

Bombs, rockets, anvils, propellers, jumping beans, volcanoes and the rare earthquake all disrupt the placing of the blocks. The volcanoes are particularly disruptive of getting rid of any tall towers that you might



Volcanic eruptions can destroy any towers you might have built

have created. Each game can last a maximum of ten minutes, which adds a sense of urgency to the game, although the gameplay itself is slow and gives you plenty of time to strategise and plan ahead.

Bontago is pretty well designed, and is immersive despite the very basic graphics. The practice mode lets you customise almost any aspect of the game, including the number of gifts, the flag count, the size of the field, the gravity, the timer and so on. The game is not meant for long hours of play, but is a fun aside if you need to take a break. **d**



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sales@adityagroup.com

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